INDIA AND THE NEIGHBOURHOOD

NEIGHBOURHOOD MAP AND FRICTION → GUJRAL DOCTRINE CARD → ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN → NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON → CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER → DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

◆ PRIMARY CORE FLOW ◆ SUBORDINATE EXTRA ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g5 and all prior artifacts unchanged

00 STAGE 00 — NEIGHBOURHOOD MAP AND FRICTION COUNT

NEIGHBOURHOOD MAP AND FRICTION COUNT · LAND OR MARITIME BORDER · PAKISTAN, CHINA, NEPAL, BHUTAN, BANGLADESH · MYANMAR, SRI LANKA, MALDIVES · AFGHANISTAN, ADJACENT AFTER PAKISTAN'S 1948 CAPTURE OF A STRIP · FRICTION RECORD · A HISTORY OF PROBLEMS WITH SIX OF THE EIGHT · NEIGHBOURHOOD IS DEFINED BY SECURITY RELEVANCE, NOT ONLY BY

LAND OR MARITIME BORDER — Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh

Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Maldives

NEAR-NEIGHBOUR — Afghanistan, adjacent after Pakistan's 1948 capture of a strip of north-western Kashmir

FRICTION RECORD — a history of problems with six of the eight bordering states

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- LAND OR MARITIME BORDER → Pakistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh,
- Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Maldives

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- NEAR-NEIGHBOUR → Afghanistan, adjacent after Pakistan's 1948 capture of a strip of north-western Kashmir
- FRICTION RECORD → a history of problems with six of the eight bordering states

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- RULE → neighbourhood is defined by security relevance, not only by contiguity
- MUST REMEMBER: Neighbourhood policy joins sovereignty, security, borders, rivers,...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → neighbourhood is defined by security relevance, not only by contiguity.

01 STAGE 01 — GUJRAL DOCTRINE CARD

GUJRAL DOCTRINE CARD · PRINCIPLE 1 · NO RECIPROCITY SOUGHT FROM SMALLER NEIGHBOURS · PRINCIPLE 2 · NO INTERFERENCE IN THEIR INTERNAL AFFAIRS · PRINCIPLE 3 · INDIAN TERRITORY NOT TO BE USED AGAINST THEM · PRINCIPLE 4

PRINCIPLE 1 — no reciprocity sought from smaller neighbours

PRINCIPLE 2 — no interference in their internal affairs

PRINCIPLE 3 — Indian territory not to be used against them

PRINCIPLE 4 — respect for their territorial integrity

DATED OFFICIAL INSTRUMENT

- PRINCIPLE 1 → no reciprocity sought from smaller neighbours
- PRINCIPLE 2 → no interference in their internal affairs

EVIDENTIARY LEVEL IT REACHES

- PRINCIPLE 3 → Indian territory not to be used against them
- PRINCIPLE 4 → respect for their territorial integrity

STATUS / CLAIM LIMIT

- PRINCIPLE 5 → bilateral and peaceful settlement of disputes
- DEFINING FEATURE → non-reciprocal accommodation, never reciprocity as a precondition

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DEFINING FEATURE → non-reciprocal accommodation, never reciprocity as a precondition.

02 STAGE 02 — ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN

ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN · SIZE ASYMMETRY · INDIA LARGER THAN THE ENTIRE IMMEDIATE NEIGHBOURHOOD COMBINED · DEPENDENCE ANXIETY · SMALLER STATES PREFER REGIONAL-FRAMEWORK ENGAGEMENT · NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION · THE DOCTRINE ANSWERS THE ANXIETY DIRECTLY · CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT

SIZE ASYMMETRY — India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined → DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement → NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly → CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time → TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined
- DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly
- CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government
- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government.

03 STAGE 03 — NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON · SMALLER STATES · BHUTAN, NEPAL, MALDIVES, SRI LANKA: GREATER INTEREST IN ECONOMIC · LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX · PAKISTAN AND BANGLADESH: MORE BILATERAL POSTURE; DISTINCT SECURITY AND · REGIONAL PREFERENCE IS REASSURANCE, NOT A REJECTION OF BILATERAL

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka	regional framework preferred because numbers give a sense of security	QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery
greater interest in economic integration	LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX → Pakistan and Bangladesh; more bilateral posture; distinct security and historical dynamics	SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

ACTOR / INTEREST

- SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka
- greater interest in economic integration

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- regional framework preferred because numbers give a sense of security
- LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX → Pakistan and Bangladesh; more bilateral posture; distinct security and historical dynamics

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery
- SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery.

04 STAGE 04 — CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER

CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER · 1 NOVEMBER 2023 · AKHAURA–AGARTALA CROSS-BORDER RAIL LINK INAUGURATED · BBIN MOTOR VEHICLES AGREEMENT SIGNED; BHUTAN NON-RATIFICATION CONSTRAINS IT · 720 MW MANGDECHHU COMMISSIONED, THEN HANDED OVER TO BHUTAN · MAY 2023 · KALADAN WATERWAY AND SITTWE PORT OPERATIONALISED; ROAD COMPONENT LAGGED · 1 JUNE 2026

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
1 NOVEMBER 2023 → Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link inaugurated	2019 / 2022 → 720 MW Mangdechhu commissioned, then handed over to Bhutan	1 JUNE 2026 → both sides still calling for Kaladan completion
2015 → BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement signed; Bhutan non-ratification constrains it	MAY 2023 → Kaladan waterway and Sittwe Port operationalised; road component lagged	RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed

ACTOR / INTEREST

- 1 NOVEMBER 2023 → Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link inaugurated
- 2015 → BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement signed; Bhutan non-ratification constrains it

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- 2019 / 2022 → 720 MW Mangdechhu commissioned, then handed over to Bhutan
- MAY 2023 → Kaladan waterway and Sittwe Port operationalised; road component lagged

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 1 JUNE 2026 → both sides still calling for Kaladan completion
- RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed.

05 STAGE 05 — DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX · SRI LANKA · SEVEN MOUS, 5 APRIL 2025; BRIEF CURRENT TO JULY · JOINT VISION 7 OCTOBER 2024; FTA TERMS OF REFERENCE · INR 4,850 CRORE LINE OF CREDIT; BRIEF CURRENT TO · INR 100 BILLION FOR THE 13TH FIVE YEAR PLAN · 2025; GELEPHU MINDFULNESS CITY SUPPORT 12 NOVEMBER 2025 · VISION, TERMS OF REFERENCE, MEMORANDUM AND CREDIT ARE PRE-DELIVERY

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
SRI LANKA → seven MoUs, 5 April 2025; brief current to July 2026; Sampur 120 MW had ground-breaking, not commissioning	INR 4,850 crore line of credit; brief current to June 2026	2025; Gelephu Mindfulness City support 12 November 2025
MALDIVES → Joint Vision 7 October 2024; FTA Terms of Reference 25 July 2025	BHUTAN → INR 100 billion for the 13th Five Year Plan 2024-29; rail MoU 29 September	LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

ACTOR / INTEREST

- SRI LANKA → seven MoUs, 5 April 2025; brief current to July 2026; Sampur 120 MW had ground-breaking, not commissioning
- MALDIVES → Joint Vision 7 October 2024; FTA Terms of Reference 25 July 2025

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- INR 4,850 crore line of credit; brief current to June 2026
- BHUTAN → INR 100 billion for the 13th Five Year Plan 2024-29; rail MoU 29 September

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 2025; Gelephu Mindfulness City support 12 November 2025
- LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments.

06 STAGE 06 — SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD

SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD · BY 3 MAY 2022 · MORE THAN USD 3 BILLION RECORDED IN ASSISTANCE DURING · USD 1 BILLION · FACILITY FOR FOOD, MEDICINES AND ESSENTIALS · USD 500 MILLION · PETROLEUM CREDIT LINE; CLOSE TO 400,000 TONNES OF FUEL · ABOUT USD 1 BILLION

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
BY 3 MAY 2022 → more than USD 3 billion recorded in assistance during 2022	USD 500 million → petroleum credit line; close to 400,000 tonnes of fuel delivered	USD 400 million → Reserve Bank of India currency swap; 25 districts covered
USD 1 billion → facility for food, medicines and essentials	ABOUT USD 1 billion → Asian Clearing Union payment deferment	LIMIT → around USD 4 billion is the full-year description; structural problems remained

ACTOR / INTEREST

- BY 3 MAY 2022 → more than USD 3 billion recorded in assistance during 2022
- USD 1 billion → facility for food, medicines and essentials

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- USD 500 million → petroleum credit line; close to 400,000 tonnes of fuel delivered
- ABOUT USD 1 billion → Asian Clearing Union payment deferment

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- USD 400 million → Reserve Bank of India currency swap; 25 districts covered
- LIMIT → around USD 4 billion is the full-year description; structural problems remained

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT → around USD 4 billion is the full-year description; structural problems remained.

07 STAGE 07 — TRANSITION-TEST TIMELINE

TRANSITION-TEST TIMELINE · 16 AUGUST 2024 · INDIA ENGAGES BANGLADESH'S INTERIM GOVERNMENT · 12 SEPTEMBER 2025 · INDIA WELCOMES NEPAL'S INTERIM GOVERNMENT UNDER SUSHILA KARKI · 20 AUGUST 2025 · INDIA PRESSES FOR EARLY INCLUSIVE ELECTIONS IN BANGLADESH · 12 FEBRUARY 2026

16 AUGUST 2024 — India engages Bangladesh's interim government → 12 SEPTEMBER 2025 — India welcomes Nepal's interim government under Sushila Karki → 20 AUGUST 2025 — India presses for early inclusive elections in Bangladesh → 12 FEBRUARY 2026 — Bangladesh parliamentary elections held → 5 MARCH 2026 — Nepal elections held

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- 16 AUGUST 2024 → India engages Bangladesh's interim government
- 12 SEPTEMBER 2025 → India welcomes Nepal's interim government under Sushila Karki

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- 20 AUGUST 2025 → India presses for early inclusive elections in Bangladesh
- 12 FEBRUARY 2026 → Bangladesh parliamentary elections held

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- 5 MARCH 2026 → Nepal elections held
- READING → India engaged the successor arrangement in each case, not the outgoing one

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: READING → India engaged the successor arrangement in each case, not the outgoing one.

08 STAGE 08 — WATER-SECURITY LEDGER

WATER-SECURITY LEDGER · 23 APRIL 2025 · CABINET COMMITTEE ON SECURITY HOLDS THE INDUS WATERS TREATY · UNTIL PAKISTAN CREDIBLY AND IRREVOCABLY ABJURES CROSS-BORDER TERRORISM SUPPORT · 16 MAY 2026 · INDIA RESTATES THAT THE COURT OF ARBITRATION IS ILLEGALLY · DECEMBER 2026 · THE 1996 GANGA WATERS TREATY EXPIRES

23 APRIL 2025 — Cabinet Committee on Security holds the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance → CONDITION — until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures cross-border terrorism support → 16 MAY 2026 — India restates that the Court of Arbitration is illegally constituted → DECEMBER 2026 — the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires → 13 FEBRUARY 2026 — India states that renewal talks had not begun

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- 23 APRIL 2025 → Cabinet Committee on Security holds the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance
- CONDITION — until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures cross-border terrorism support

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- 16 MAY 2026 → India restates that the Court of Arbitration is illegally constituted
- DECEMBER 2026 — the 1996 Ganga Waters Treaty expires

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- 13 FEBRUARY 2026 → India states that renewal talks had not begun
- DOCTRINE TEST → non-reciprocity is least stable where the shared resource is finite

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DOCTRINE TEST → non-reciprocity is least stable where the shared resource is finite.

09 STAGE 09 — STATUS DISTINCTIONS THAT DECIDE CLOSE OPTIONS

STATUS DISTINCTIONS THAT DECIDE CLOSE OPTIONS · AN EXECUTIVE DECISION ON OPERATION; EXPRESSLY NOT TREATY TERMINATION · UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 · TO STOP ALL MILITARY ACTIVITIES; NOT A CEASEFIRE AGREEMENT · EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 · MISSION LEVEL CHANGED; NO RECOGNITION DECLARATION · TERMS OF REFERENCE · NEGOTIATIONS LAUNCHED; NOT A CONCLUDED FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
ABEYANCE — an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination	EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration	CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing...
UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement	TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement	ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination

ACTOR / INTEREST

- ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination
- UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration
- TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing...
- ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing.

10 STAGE 10 — DOMESTIC AND EXTERNAL CONSTRAINT BAND

DOMESTIC AND EXTERNAL CONSTRAINT BAND · TEESTA SHOWS INDIAN STATE-LEVEL INTERESTS CONSTRAINING A BILATERAL AGREEMENT · PARTNER POLITICS · INDIA MUST CLOSELY FOLLOW NEIGHBOURING POLITICAL TRENDS · THE GUJRAL PRINCIPLE SITS IN TENSION WITH THAT NECESSITY · OUTSIDE POWER · SIKRI'S DATED CRITIQUE OF EXTERNAL GUIDANCE OF SOUTH ASIA · CITE THE CONSTRAINT WITH ITS DATE AND ITS AUTHOR

FEDERAL — Teesta shows Indian state-level interests constraining a bilateral agreement

PARTNER POLITICS — India must closely follow neighbouring political trends

NON-INTERFERENCE — the Gujral principle sits in tension with that necessity

OUTSIDE POWER — Sikri's dated critique of external guidance of South Asia policy

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- FEDERAL — Teesta shows Indian state-level interests constraining a bilateral agreement
- PARTNER POLITICS → India must closely follow neighbouring political trends

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- NON-INTERFERENCE → the Gujral principle sits in tension with that necessity
- OUTSIDE POWER → Sikri's dated critique of external guidance of South Asia policy

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- RULE → cite the constraint with its date and its author, never as current fact
- EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Use named India-centric evidence such...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → cite the constraint with its date and its author, never as current fact.

11 STAGE 11 — ANSWER SPINE FOR A NEIGHBOURHOOD DEMAND

ANSWER SPINE FOR A NEIGHBOURHOOD DEMAND · ESTABLISH STRUCTURAL ASYMMETRY AND THE NON-RECIPROCAL DOCTRINAL RESPONSE · DISTINGUISH SMALLER-STATE AND LARGER-STATE ENGAGEMENT PATTERNS BY NAME · CITE ONE DATED INSTRUMENT WITH ITS EXACT EVIDENTIARY LEVEL · APPLY THE IMPLEMENTATION-CREDIBILITY TEST ACROSS A CHANGE OF GOVERNMENT

OPEN — establish structural asymmetry and the non-reciprocal doctrinal response → BUILD — distinguish smaller-state and larger-state engagement patterns by name → TEST — cite one dated instrument with its exact evidentiary level and its limitation → CLOSE — apply the implementation-credibility test across a change of government

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- OPEN → establish structural asymmetry and the non-reciprocal doctrinal response
- BUILD → distinguish smaller-state and larger-state engagement patterns by name

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- TEST → cite one dated instrument with its exact evidentiary level and its limitation
- CLOSE → apply the implementation-credibility test across a change of government

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- OPEN → establish structural asymmetry and the non-reciprocal doctrinal response
- BUILD → distinguish smaller-state and larger-state engagement patterns by name

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → apply the implementation-credibility test across a change of government.

E EXTRA — SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · BILATERAL SUMMIT-LEVEL MECHANISMS (ANNUAL OR PERIODIC LEADER-LEVEL · MEA BILATERAL BRIEFS (INDIA-SRI LANKA AND INDIA-BHUTAN, CURRENT TO · POWER-GRID AND TRANSIT PROTOCOLS ARE TYPICALLY NEGOTIATED AND RENEWED · REGIONAL-FRAMEWORK OVERLAY (SAARC, BIMSTEC) PROVIDES THE MULTILATERAL · BOUNDARY CASE — HISTORICAL INTERVENTION VS. STATED NON-INTERFERENCE · BOUNDARY CASE — SMALLER-STATE HEDGING · EVEN NEIGHBOURS THAT VALUE

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE AND INSTRUMENT DEPTH

- CAUTION: Bilateral summit-level mechanisms (annual or periodic leader-level
- MEA bilateral briefs (India-Sri Lanka and India-Bhutan, current to July
- CAUTION: Power-grid and transit protocols are typically negotiated and renewed
- CAUTION: Regional-framework overlay (SAARC, BIMSTEC) provides the multilateral

STATUS, DATE AND FIGURE LIMIT

- CAUTION: Boundary case — historical intervention vs. stated non-interference:
- CAUTION: Boundary case — smaller-state hedging: even neighbours that value
- CAUTION: Boundary case — Afghanistan as a near-neighbour: Tharoor's inclusion of
- CAUTION: Regime change discontinuity risk: any government transition in a

COMPARATIVE DIPLOMATIC NUANCE

- CAUTION: Boundary case — the implementation-credibility test with dated
- CAUTION: Non-reciprocity has fiscal and political cost: the Gujral Doctrine's
- CAUTION: Regional-framework preference vs. bilateral delivery tension: smaller
- CAUTION: Domestic political engagement vs. non-interference principle: the need

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels